

Bosnia's 'Balkan Blues' Music Honored by UNESCO

Every Friday, musician Enes Salman performs the Sevdalinka, an ancient form of love song from Bosnia and Herzegovina.

Sevdalinka was recently included in UNESCO's National Inventory of Intangible Cultural Heritage. UNESCO is The United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization.

Sevdalinka is often called the Balkan Blues. It is a somewhat sad form of urban love song that dates to the 1500s. It is a mix of South Slavic spoken poetry and music of the Ottoman Empire.

Salman is among only a few musicians keeping the tradition alive.

"I have been playing and singing Sevdalinka since I was 14," he said before a recent performance.

Customers, at a small cafe, listen to the traditional love song Sevdalinka, in Sarajevo, Bosnia and Herzegovina, December 27, 2024. (REUTERS/Amel Emric)

Sevdalinka is often performed a cappella. That means it is sung without musical instruments. Sometimes the performer sings with traditional instruments like a lute. This form, or genre, of music has been carried from generation to generation through performances at family gatherings.

In recent years, younger musicians have brought modern versions of Sevdalinka to audiences around the world.

One of them is Damir Imamovic. His father and grandfather were famous Sevdalinka performers. In 2020 and 2021, Imamovic won awards from two world music publications, Songlines and Transglobal, for best European album.

Imamovic supports Sevdalinka internationally through his SevdahLab project. The project helped build support for the music's inclusion on UNESCO's World Heritage list.

"I realized how little the public knows about the Sevdalinka genre and wanted to reveal the story behind that music," he said.

Bosnian musician Zanin Berbic plays the saz, a traditional instrument, during a performance of the traditional love song Sevdalinka, in Sarajevo, Bosnia and Herzegovina, December 20, 2024. (REUTERS/Amel Emric)

Zanin Berbic is a 28-year-old ethno-musicologist. He works as a curator in the music department of Bosnia's Regional Museum in Sarajevo, organizing, protecting, and bringing

attention to music. He also plays saz, a long-necked lute used in Ottoman classical music. He said that Sevdalinka tells the story of Bosnia's history.

Berbic said, "Most of my days I spend either singing or playing Sevdalinka songs or reading or talking about them. Sevdalinka is my life," he said.

I'm Anna Matteo.

Daria Sito-Sucic reported this story for Reuters from Sarajevo. Anna Matteo adapted it for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

a cappella - foreign term. การร้องเพลงโดยไม่มีเครื่องดนตรีประกอบ

genre - n. ประเภทของศิลปะที่แตกต่างจากประเภทอื่น

audience - n. ผู้ชม, ผู้ฟัง, กลุ่มคนที่มารับชมหรือรับฟังการแสดง

ethno-musicology - n. การศึกษาดนตรีในบริบททางสังคมและวัฒนธรรม; การศึกษาดนตรีพื้นเมือง/ชาติพันธุ์

curator - n. ผู้ดูแล, ภัณฑารักษ์ (บุคคลที่ดูแลจัดการคอลเล็กชันของวัตถุบางประเภท)

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. Who is Enes Salman and what does he do every Friday?

- A. A composer who writes modern Sevdalinka songs.
- B. A musician who performs Sevdalinka, an ancient love song.
- C. A music historian who studies Bosnian folk music.
- D. A cafe owner who hosts musical events.

2. What recent recognition did Sevdalinka receive?

- A. It was featured in a global music festival.
- B. It was added to a list of endangered cultural practices.
- C. It was included in UNESCO's National Inventory of Intangible Cultural Heritage.
- D. It received an award for best European album.

3. Which description best characterizes Sevdalinka?

- A. A joyful dance music from the Ottoman Empire.
- B. A modern form of protest song from the Balkans.
- C. A melancholic urban love song with historical roots.
- D. A fast-paced instrumental piece for celebrations.

4. What are the two main cultural influences that form Sevdalinka?

- A. Western classical music and traditional Bosnian folk tales.
- B. South Slavic spoken poetry and music of the Ottoman Empire.
- C. Ancient Greek hymns and contemporary European pop.
- D. African-American blues and Latin American salsa.

5. What is suggested about Enes Salman's role in the Sevdalinka tradition?

- A. He is the only musician performing Sevdalinka today.
- B. He is one of many musicians who recently started performing Sevdalinka.
- C. He is among a small number of musicians dedicated to preserving Sevdalinka.
- D. He is primarily a researcher of Sevdalinka, not a performer.

6. How long has Enes Salman been involved with Sevdalinka?

- A. Only for the last few years.
- B. Since he was a teenager.
- C. Since he started performing professionally.
- D. For most of his adult life.

7. What does it mean if a Sevdalinka song is performed 'a cappella'?

- A. It features a large choir.
- B. It is sung with many modern instruments.
- C. It is performed without any musical instruments.
- D. It includes a complex instrumental solo.

8. How has Sevdalinka traditionally been passed down through generations?

- A. Through formal music schools.
- B. By publishing written musical scores.
- C. Through performances at family gatherings.
- D. By distributing recordings internationally.

9. What recent development has occurred regarding Sevdalinka?

- A. It has become exclusively an academic study.
- B. Younger musicians are creating contemporary versions and reaching global audiences.
- C. Its popularity has declined significantly worldwide.
- D. It is now only performed with traditional instruments.

10. Who is Damir Imamovic, and what is notable about his background and achievements?

- A. He is a music critic who writes about Sevdalinka.
- B. He is a modern Sevdalinka performer from a family of performers who won international awards.
- C. He is a historian who documented the origins of Sevdalinka.
- D. He is a luthier who makes traditional instruments for Sevdalinka.

11. What was a key contribution of Damir Imamovic's SevdahLab project?

- A. It established new music schools for Sevdalinka.
- B. It developed modern instruments for Sevdalinka performances.
- C. It helped garner international support for Sevdalinka's UNESCO World Heritage listing.
- D. It created a documentary film about Sevdalinka.

12. What motivated Damir Imamovic to start the SevdahLab project?

- A. He wanted to make Sevdalinka more profitable for musicians.
- B. He felt the public lacked understanding of the Sevdalinka genre's story.
- C. He aimed to update Sevdalinka to appeal to younger audiences.
- D. He intended to replace traditional Sevdalinka with modern versions.

13. What is Zanin Berbic's profession and what does he do at the Regional Museum in Sarajevo?

- A. He is a musician who exclusively performs Sevdalinka.
- B. He is a curator and ethno-musicologist, organizing and protecting music.
- C. He is a historian who writes books about Bosnian culture.
- D. He is a music teacher specializing in traditional instruments.

14. According to Zanin Berbic, what cultural significance does Sevdalinka hold for Bosnia?

- A. It primarily serves as modern entertainment.
- B. It reflects the future musical trends of the region.
- C. It tells the story of Bosnia's history.
- D. It is a foreign musical import with little local relevance.

15. How does Zanin Berbic describe his personal connection to Sevdalinka?

- A. It is a casual hobby he enjoys occasionally.
- B. It is a significant part of his daily life and identity.
- C. It is simply a professional obligation for him.
- D. He finds it to be an interesting historical subject.